



the responsibility filmmakers bear. *Ramayana*'s makers encountered a wave of criticism on social media when they came out with the first teaser of the film, as eagle-eyed viewers flagged what they saw as excessive reliance on CGI. It underscored that audiences may be keen to see mythological epics on screen, but they are equally exacting about how they are brought to life.

Shailesh Kapoor, co-founder of media and entertainment research and consulting agency Ormax, also cautions against Bollywood's tendency to overplay an emerging trend. "Hindi cinema has an unenviable ability to identify an emerging opportunity and then eliminate it with oversupply," he says. The success of *Hanuman Ansh*, he argues, shows that a devotional film need not be "a giant spectacle" to strike a chord with audiences. Assuming that every film with a religious or spiritual undertone will find an audience, he warns, would be a costly mistake for producers. "This is a genre where the success of a film is the most unpredictable compared to other genres. One doesn't know if and how the devotee base will endorse the film," says Kapoor. "A genre built around belief can probably detect cynicism faster than most."

Chaturvedi welcomes the growing interest in spiritual roots, but worries that filmmakers increasingly see faith as a bankable formula and a certified cash cow. "What matters is the sincerity and sensitivity with which you make the subject," he says. "Unless you are a believer, the film will not work." Before embarking on a second instalment of Baba, he has another spiritual project on the horizon: *Ram Bola*, a film on the saint-poet Tulsidas.

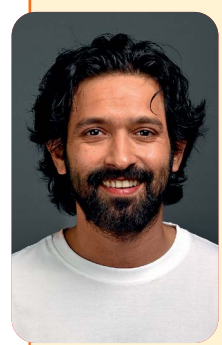
Whether these films herald a spiritual awakening in Indian cinema remains to be seen. What is clear, however, is that astronomical budgets and lavish sets are no longer prerequisites for box-office success. Nor are big stars. The overnight rise of Shobhinaw, the lead actor of *Hanuman Ansh*, is a case in point. The son of teachers in Lucknow, he spent nearly a decade struggling in Mumbai before serendipity landed him the role. Two months after the film's release, he is still out promoting it, sporting the same look and even the demeanour of his character. "*Baba to ban gaya hoon*," he says with a laugh. He has no qualms about being typecast, nor is he anxious about what lies ahead. "I won't do something radically different," he says. "I will only take up offers *jo meri maryaada ke andar hain* [that fall within my moral values]." He is content to leave his cinematic journey in the hands of the god and guru he believes brought him this far. "I didn't have anything before. How can I be greedy now? If I didn't learn this much from Baba, then what's the point?" ■

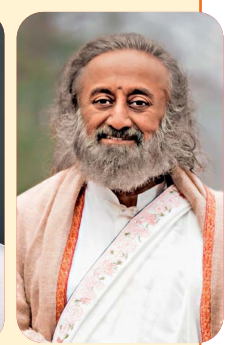
***—with Anilesh S. Mahajan***

### *White*

**Director:** *Montoo Bassi*
**Producers:** *Peacecraft Pictures, Mahaveer Jain Films & Conscious Studios*
**Expected release:** *2027*

**Vikrant Massey calls his "attempt to step into the magnanimous shoes of Gurudev", a.k.a. Sri Sri Ravi Shankar, a futile one, but one he is grateful for. It focuses on his role as peacemaker between the Colombian government and insurgent forces.**





### *Ram Bola*

**Director:** *Vishal Chaturvedi*
**Producers:** *Mahaveer Jain & Amit Upadhyay*
**Expected release:** *2027-28*

**After shaking up the box office with *Hanuman Ansh*, Vishal Chaturvedi turns to another icon of *bhakti*, with a biopic on Hindu saint-poet Tulsidas, whose life journey before composing Ramcharitmanas and Hanuman Chalisa have inspired films before.**

